Decoding Pathology: Why Row 2 ($K = 0$) Collapsed by 12.00%

Row 1: Format-Locked (20 Latents)

```
Input Prefill:
  <think> <|latent_pad|> x 20 </think>\n

Generated Output Tokens:
  <answer>B</answer><|im_end|>

Characteristics:
  • Exactly 7.0 tokens across ALL 700 items
  • Variance σ = 0.00
  • Mean Latency: 0.36 seconds / sample
  • Regex extraction: 100% clean parse
```

Row 2: Unlocked Empty Prefill (K=0)

```
Input Prefill:
  (empty assistant turn)

Generated Output Tokens:
  <think>THOUGHT: The red object is left of...
  wait, looking closer at point 2...
  repeating: 'The 48th image is a larger...'

Characteristics:
  • Mean tokens: 138.5 (Max: 1,024 cap)
  • Mean Latency: 175.12 seconds / sample
  • Catastrophic repetition loops (IQ #52)
  • 3 hard regex parse crashes
```